

Chapter 163-3

//

She had clearly just seen Yujiang Bridge not long ago, and had come to this neighborhood too, but at that time the weather had felt gray and hazy.

Even the Yujiang River seemed to be covered in fog.

But during the day, everything was clear. The clouds had parted and the fog had dispersed.

As Liang Shi passed by Yujiang, she casually remarked: "The weather is really nice today."

Xu Qingzhu glanced over: "Yes."

But there was no sun today. The clouds were piled layer upon layer, gray and white intermingled.

There was a traffic jam on Yujiang Bridge, barely able to move an inch.

The water of the Yujiang wasn't as clear as before either.

After Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu got home, Liang Shi changed her shoes with practiced ease. Then, when Xu Qingzhu was about to bend down to change her shoes, Liang Shi immediately half-squatted and pressed down on her foot, took off her shoes, picked up slippers from the shoe rack, and carefully put them on for her.

Xu Qingzhu stood there, stunned.

Liang Shi looked up at her from this posture. "Did I change your shoes like this before?"

Xu Qingzhu slowly nodded.

Back then, Liang Shi had even kissed the top of her foot.

But Liang Shi had been drunk that time. The current Liang Shi was sober.

Perhaps the shoes didn't fit properly—the new shoes she bought were slightly too small, causing Xu Qingzhu's heels to be rubbed red. The skin near her pinky toe and big toe looked like it was about to peel.

Liang Shi stared, then suddenly reached out and pressed next to her big toe. Xu Qingzhu gasped in pain and instinctively tried to pull back, but Liang Shi held her foot and placed it on her own leg.

"What are you doing?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi sighed: "The shoes don't fit. New shoes need to be broken in before you can wear them."

"But you still have to wear them to break them in." Xu Qingzhu pulled her foot from Liang Shi's hands. "These are pretty, and I like them, so I can wear them. Whether they fit or not doesn't matter—as long as I can put them on, it's fine."

Liang Shi was helpless: "Alright then."

She got up to go to the bathroom to get hot water for a foot soak, but when she reached the doorway, she suddenly realized: "Are you using a metaphor?"

"It's a simile," Xu Qingzhu said without any bashfulness.

Liang Shi: "....."

Her ears felt a bit hot from what was said.

Xu Qingzhu was arranged to sit on the sofa by Liang Shi, while Liang Shi went to prepare medicinal foot soak packets and hot water, bringing them to the living room for Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi's sleeves were rolled up, revealing a small section of her forearm.

Her hair accidentally fell down and nearly dropped into the water. Xu Qingzhu caught it just in time, saving her hair from disaster.

Liang Shi bent down and squatted there, placing Xu Qingzhu's feet in the basin. "Soaking will make it feel better."

Xu Qingzhu patted the spot beside her. "Then come join me."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Aren't you hungry? I'll go make you something to eat," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her.

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu asked slowly in a melancholic tone: "Liang Shi, are you caring about me or the baby?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi was stunned: "You, of course."

Xu Qingzhu's mood improved slightly, but she still complained: "But you only started being this nice to me after I said I was pregnant. I think you love the baby more."

Liang Shi: "....."

"How can you think that?" Liang Shi asked in surprise.

Xu Qingzhu was even more surprised: "Why wouldn't I? Think about what you've done."

Liang Shi: "....."

"When you first entered the office, you were still asking if I'd considered the divorce," Xu Qingzhu said. "Then after I said I was pregnant, you said we wouldn't divorce. If it's not because of the child, what else could it be?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"It's because you cried." Liang Shi was squatting, needing to tilt her head up slightly to see Xu Qingzhu's face—just the right angle to look up at her.

Those light brown pupils looked at Xu Qingzhu earnestly: "You were crying like that. My heart shattered."

"Don't you love yourself the most?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi paused: "But when I'm still intact, I can still feel sad and hurt because of you."

"Yet you still left so resolutely." Just thinking about that day's scene made Xu Qingzhu want to cry. Tears were welling up in her eyes, and her voice became choked again: "When I woke up that morning, I felt..."

Liang Shi was afraid to hear it, yet also curious.

So she looked at her gently, listening to her speak slowly.

Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath before saying: "That day, I almost jumped off the building."

Actually, from her tone, one could tell that making this request wasn't Liang Shi's intention.

But for Xu Qingzhu, it was an extremely painful thing.

She kept negating herself then rebuilding, negating again, rebuilding again, over and over.

Her mental state reached the breaking point time after time.

Yet even so, she never wailed loudly—she just sat there, numbly shedding tears.

Hearing this, Liang Shi was alarmed: "What were you thinking?"

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes. Half of her tears fell while the other half hung on her eyelashes.

She said quietly: "You probably forgot that I used to have a mental illness."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's heart felt like it was stuffed with ten thousand sour plums—sour and swollen.

Mist gradually formed in her eyes too.

But Xu Qingzhu looked at her and smiled, lightly licking her lips before slowly leaning down.

Gently closing her eyes, she placed a kiss on Liang Shi's lips.

Lips softly touching lips.

With wet traces of moisture.

Liang Shi felt both angry and upset. "How can you be so foolish?"

"But what can I do?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I had no other choice."

Liang Shi didn't dare look into her eyes anymore. She lowered her gaze and washed Xu Qingzhu's feet.

Xu Qingzhu said again: "Come up here. Let's soak our feet together."

Liang Shi was too embarrassed to go up—she didn't have the face for it.

But then Xu Qingzhu said: "Don't you want to be closer to me?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi also took off her socks and sat beside her.

Their feet touched in the water. Xu Qingzhu's head rested on Liang Shi's shoulder.

The house became quiet—so quiet that they could almost hear each other's heartbeats.

Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu: "When did you find out?"

Xu Qingzhu answered: "About ten days ago."

"Then you..." Liang Shi didn't even dare to ask her directly, speaking somewhat timidly.

But Xu Qingzhu turned her head to face her, both hands cupping her face, their eyes meeting.
"Liang Shi, do you feel very guilty?"

Liang Shi nodded.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Then love me a little more."

Liang Shi's hand rested on the back of her neck as she slowly nodded.

Xu Qingzhu leaned forward, her voice even softer: "Just a little bit is enough."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. After a long while, as their lips met, she made a sincere and earnest promise: "From now on, I will love you more than I love myself."